Engage

Product plan and walkthrough

A meeting engagement layer that runs beside any video meeting.
The host pastes a link in the meeting chat, and attendees take small, optional actions on a second screen.

Date	12 October 2026
Status	Phase 1 prototype built and tested. Plan under review.
Primary device	Laptop, second window beside the meeting
Screenshots	Taken from the working prototype, using a simulated 14-person meeting

1. Summary
2. Walkthrough in 9 steps
3. Who sees what
4. Where Engage lives on the laptop
5. Keeping it from pulling people away
6. Games and attention checks
7. Lessons from Read AI
8. Roadmap and Phase 1 status
9. Metrics, pilots and risks
10. Decisions and next steps

1. SUMMARY

The problem, the idea, and where we are

The problem

In a 1 to 2 hour corporate meeting, most people speak for about five minutes and sit idle the rest. Hosts and senior people want everyone engaged, but attendees do not want it to feel like micromanagement.

The idea

Engage is a second screen, not a video platform. Attendees join from one link with no account and take small actions: reactions, questions, polls, light games. The host sees how the room is doing as a group, not who is idle.

What is built today

- **Host console:** invite link, code and chat message; live room pulse and engagement chart with dip detection; polls, pulse checks, recall quizzes and word clouds; question queue; reaction counts; game windows, bingo and predictions; Focus moment; quiet mode; post-meeting summary. 26 automated tests pass.
- **Attendee view:** no-login join with a disclosure of what the host can see; reactions; questions with votes and an anonymous option; answering prompts; bingo and predictions with private points; private notes; personal recap.

What comes next

- Run three real pilot meetings and measure participation and distraction.
- Add a floating mini window with a collapsed state and a presenting mode, so Engage never competes with the person sharing.
- Add a recall check, agenda segments, and a host-only coach summary.
- Persistence and host access from any browser, then a calendar-created meeting.

> **Design stance.** Engage measures only actions taken inside Engage. It does not read faces, voices or tabs, and it does not guess who is speaking or idle. This is the main difference from tools that observe and score people.

Six principles

Principle	What it means in the product
The meeting always wins	One click pauses every prompt and game (Focus moment). Prompts expire and never repeat.
Measure only what Engage can see	Engagement means actions inside Engage. No speaker or idle guessing.
Transparent by default	A plain-language screen at join lists what the host can and cannot see.
Aggregate first, never ranked	Group results only. No leaderboards. Poll answers are never tied to names.

Invitations, not accusations	Suggestions go to the host. Nudges go to everyone, never to chosen people.
Zero friction	No account, no install, under 10 seconds to join.

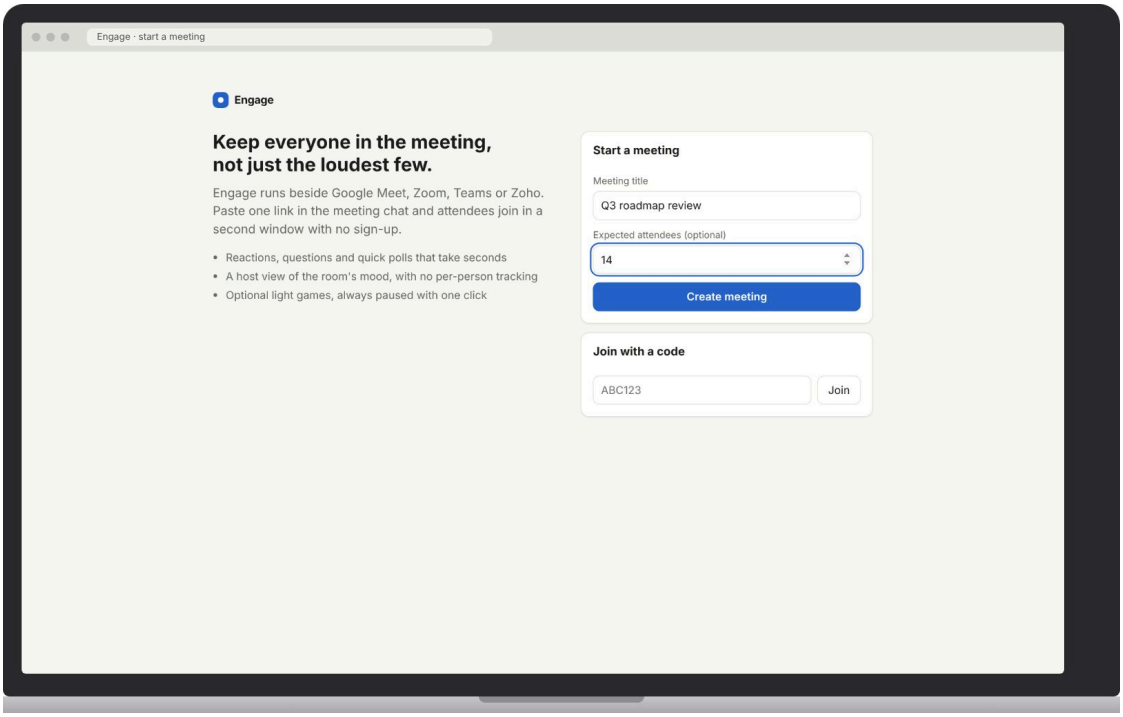
2. WALKTHROUGH

How a meeting runs, in 9 steps

Every screenshot below is from the working prototype. Attendee screens sit in a half-width window beside a placeholder video call, which is how a laptop user would use it today.

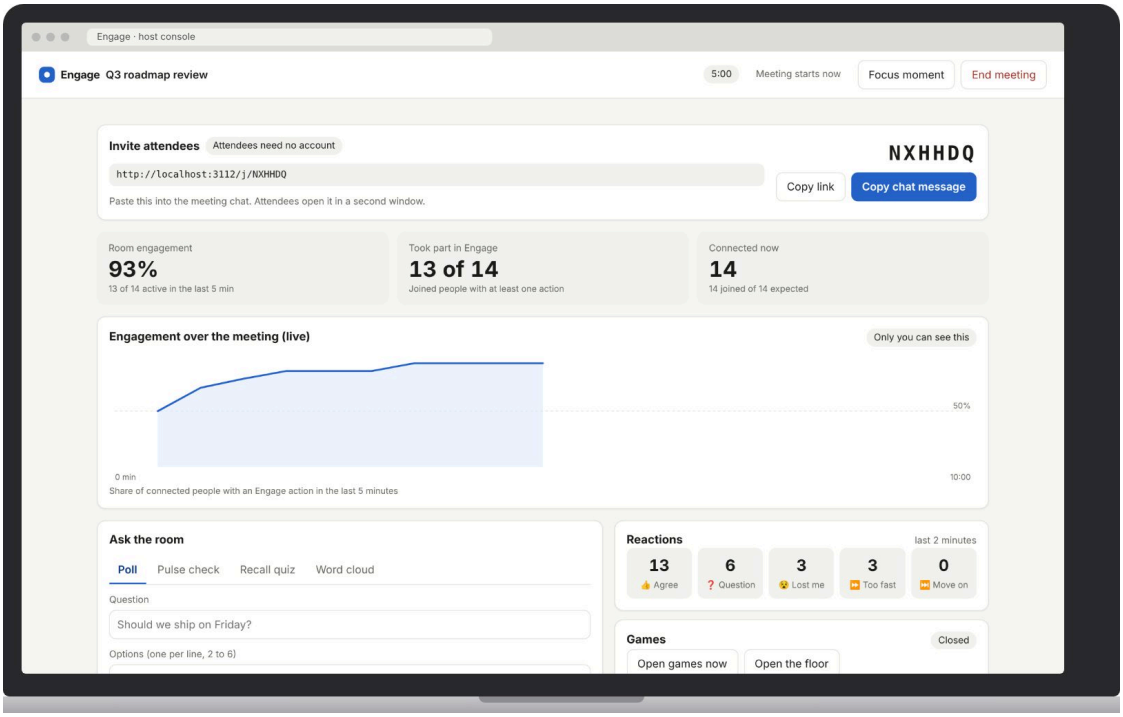
1 The host starts a meeting

The host enters a title and, optionally, how many people to expect. There is no account for attendees, and the host needs none for this prototype.



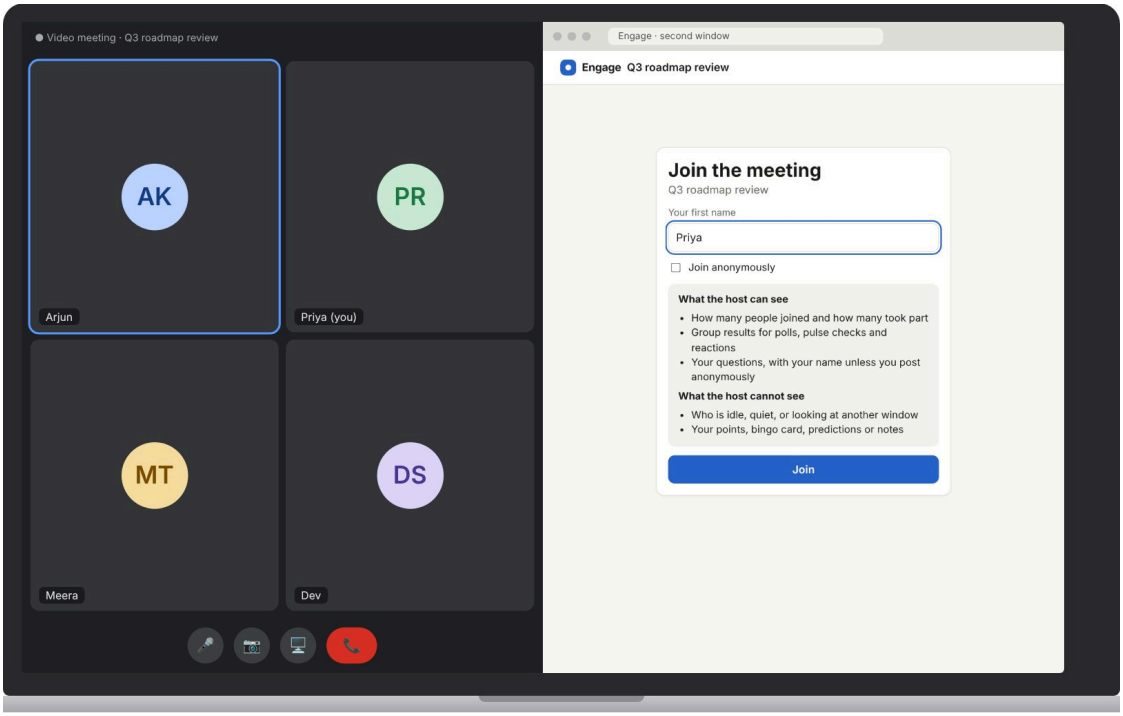
2 The host shares the link

Engage gives a link, a six-character code and a ready-to-paste chat message. Three tiles show the room at a glance: engagement, how many took part, and how many are connected.



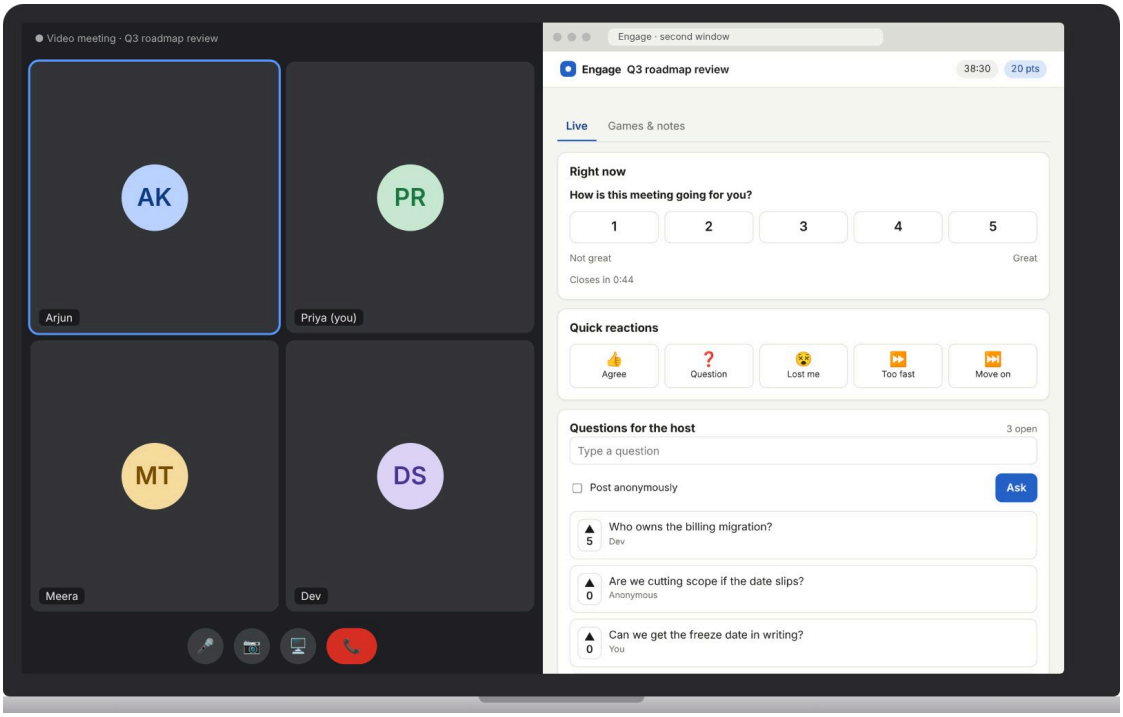
3 An attendee joins and sees what the host can see

Joining takes a first name or the Anonymous option. Before joining, the attendee reads what the host can and cannot see. Points, bingo cards, predictions and notes stay private to each attendee.



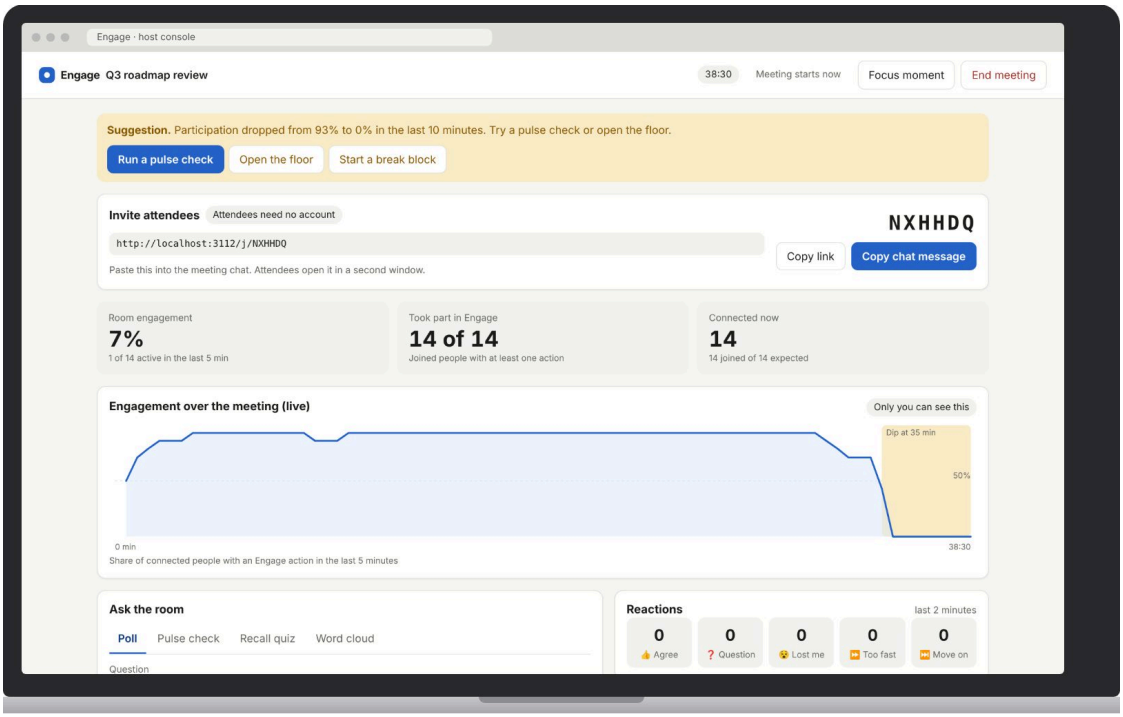
4 The attendee takes part without leaving the call

A prompt from the host appears in the second window. This one is a pulse check with a countdown. Below it are quick reactions and a question box with votes. There is no sound and no notification.



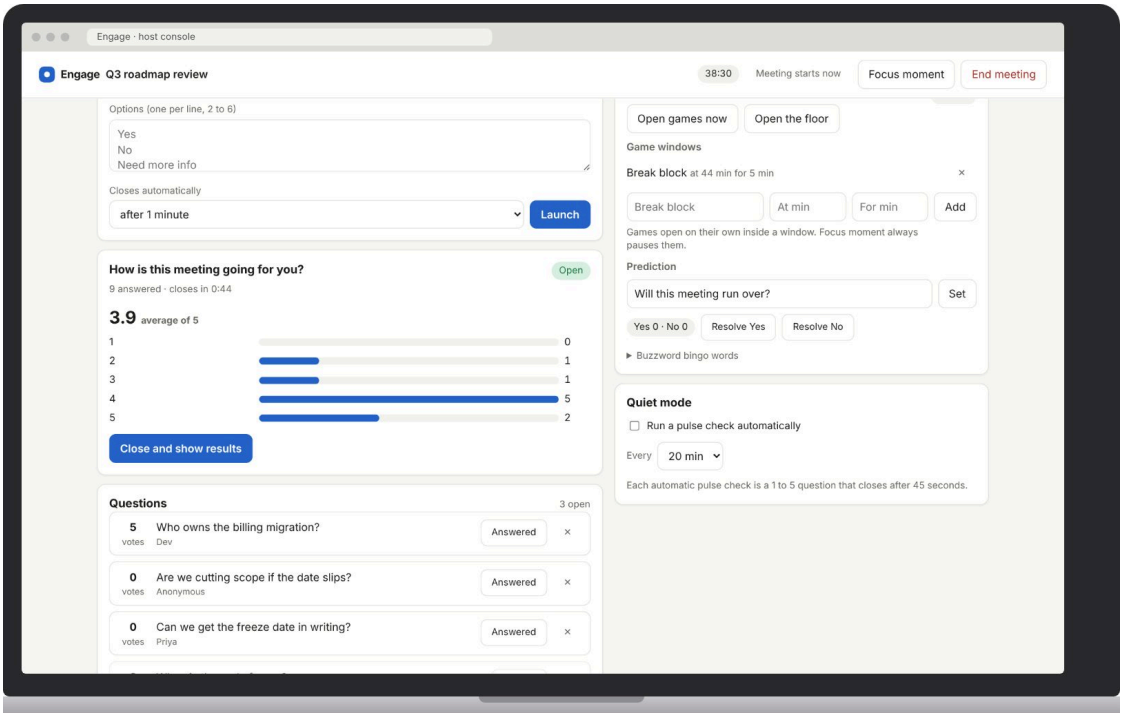
5 The host spots a dip and acts

Engagement is the share of connected people with an action in the last five minutes. After a quiet stretch it drops, the chart marks the dip, and Engage suggests three responses. Nothing goes to attendees until the host chooses.



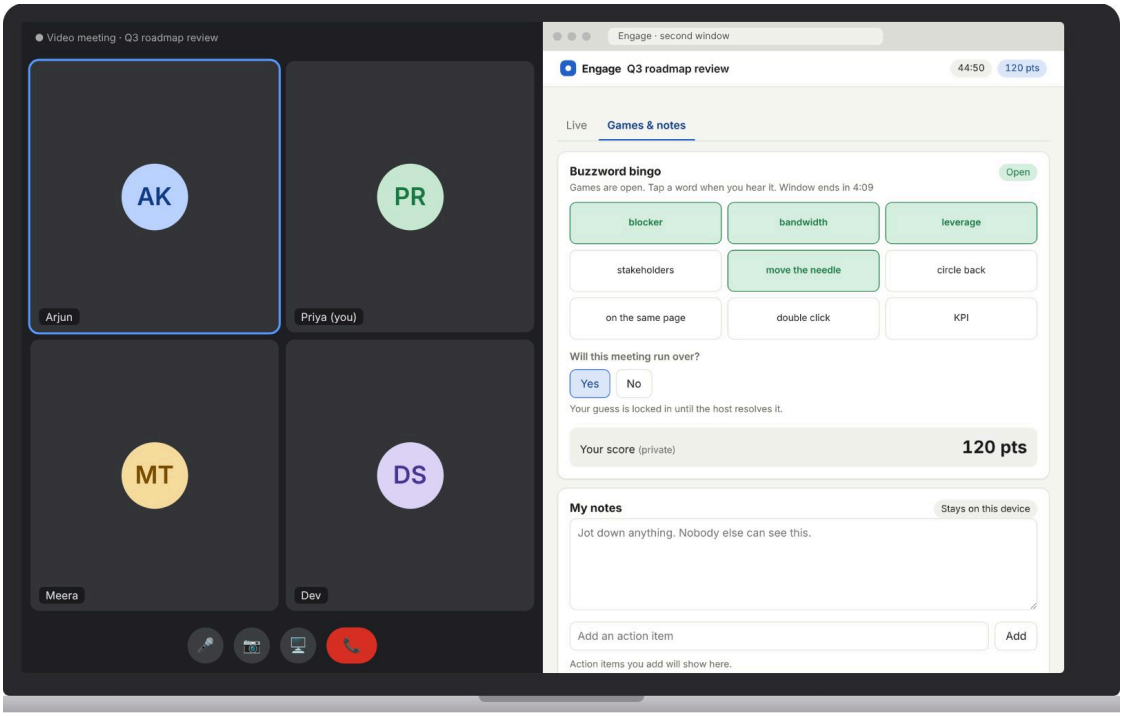
6 The host asks the room

The host ran the suggested pulse check. Results build live for the host, while attendees see group results only after the host closes it. Prompts close on their own after a set time.



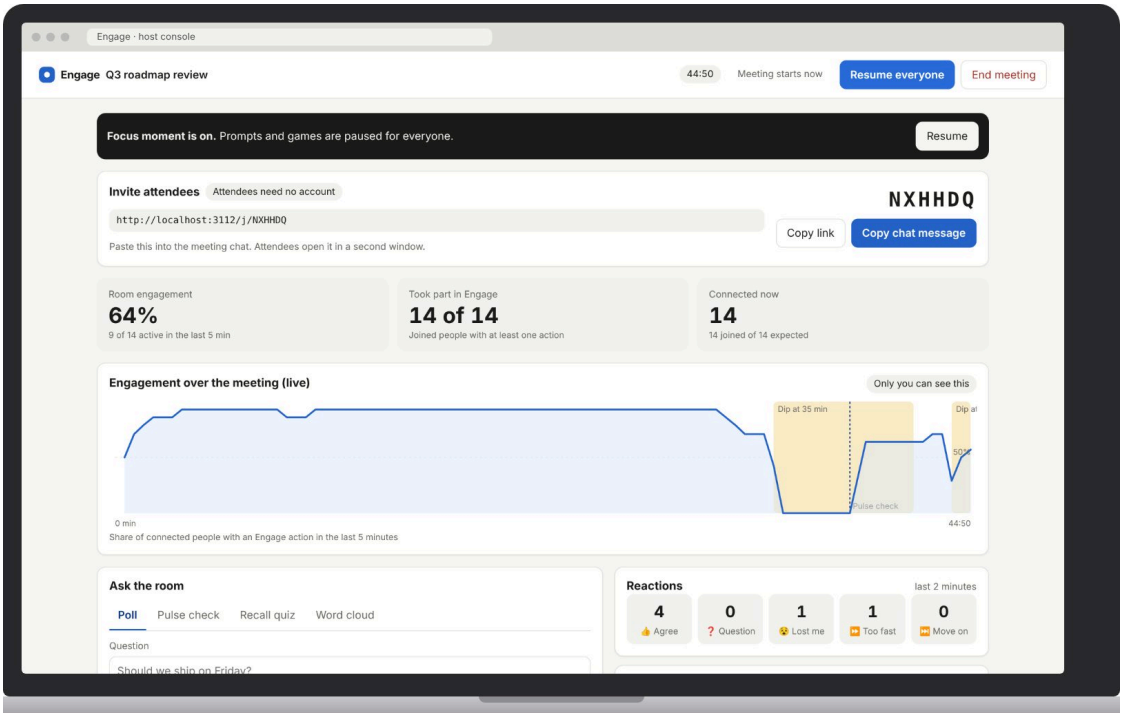
7 Games open only in host-set windows

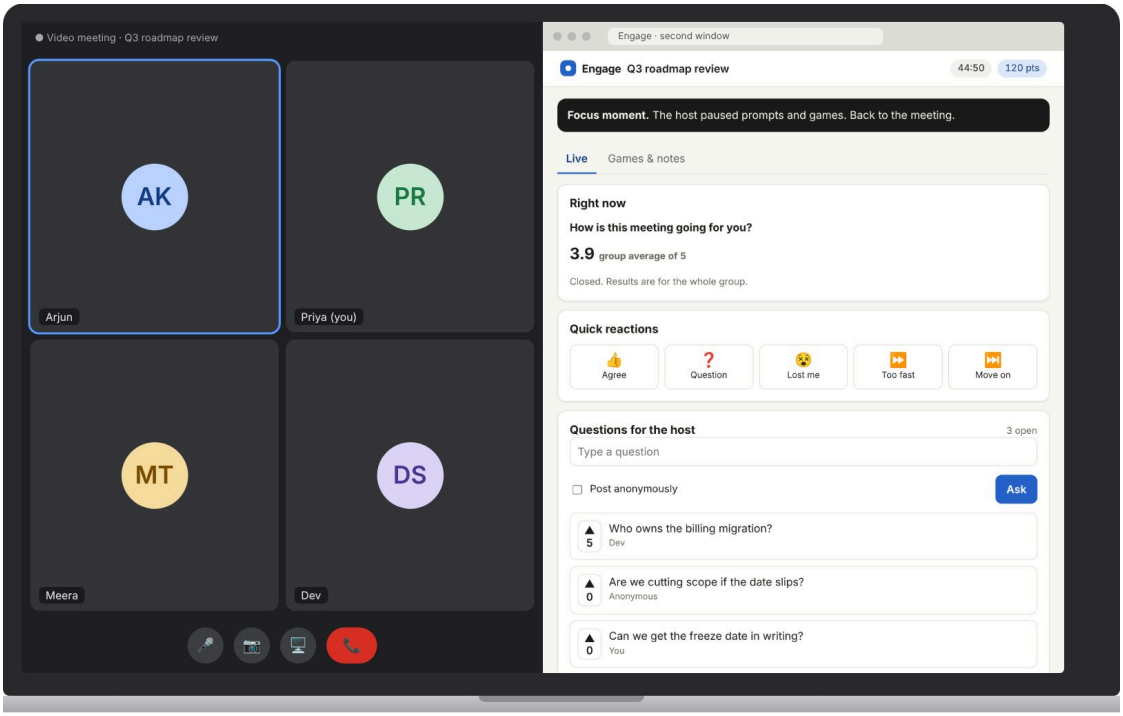
At 44 minutes a five-minute break block opened. Bingo is self-marked, so players have to listen. The prediction is one tap, and the score is private. Notes stay on the attendee's device.



8 The host can pause everything with one click

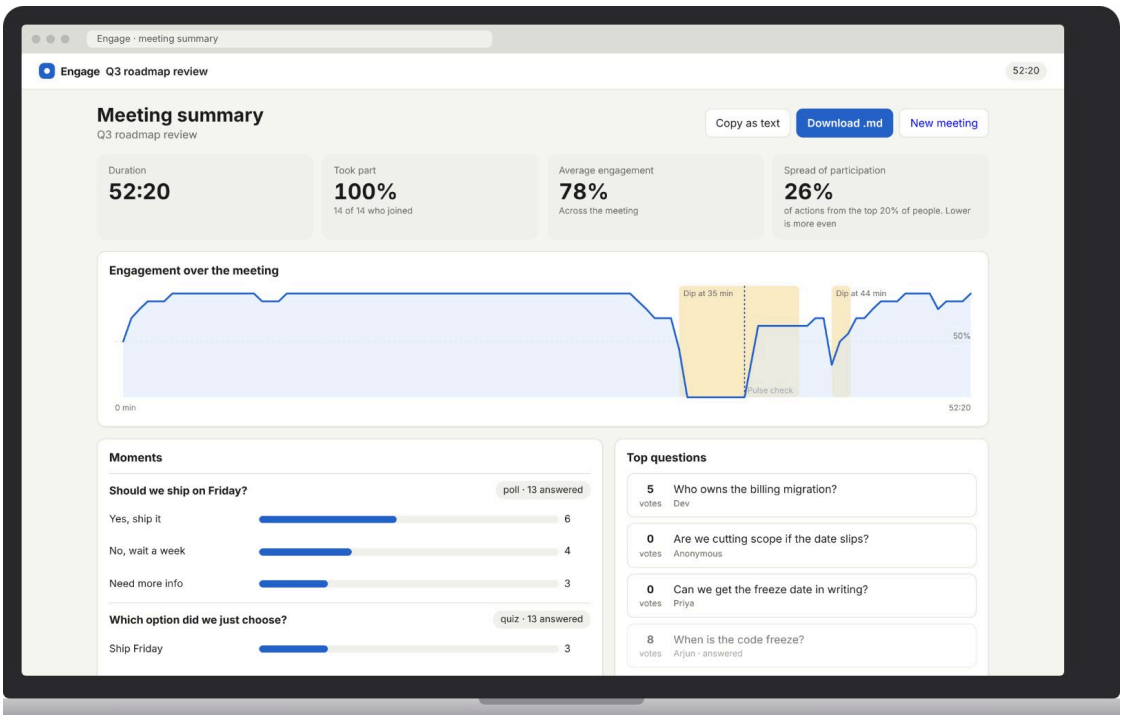
Focus moment pauses all prompts and games for everyone. Attendees see a plain banner explaining why. This is the main protection for important moments.

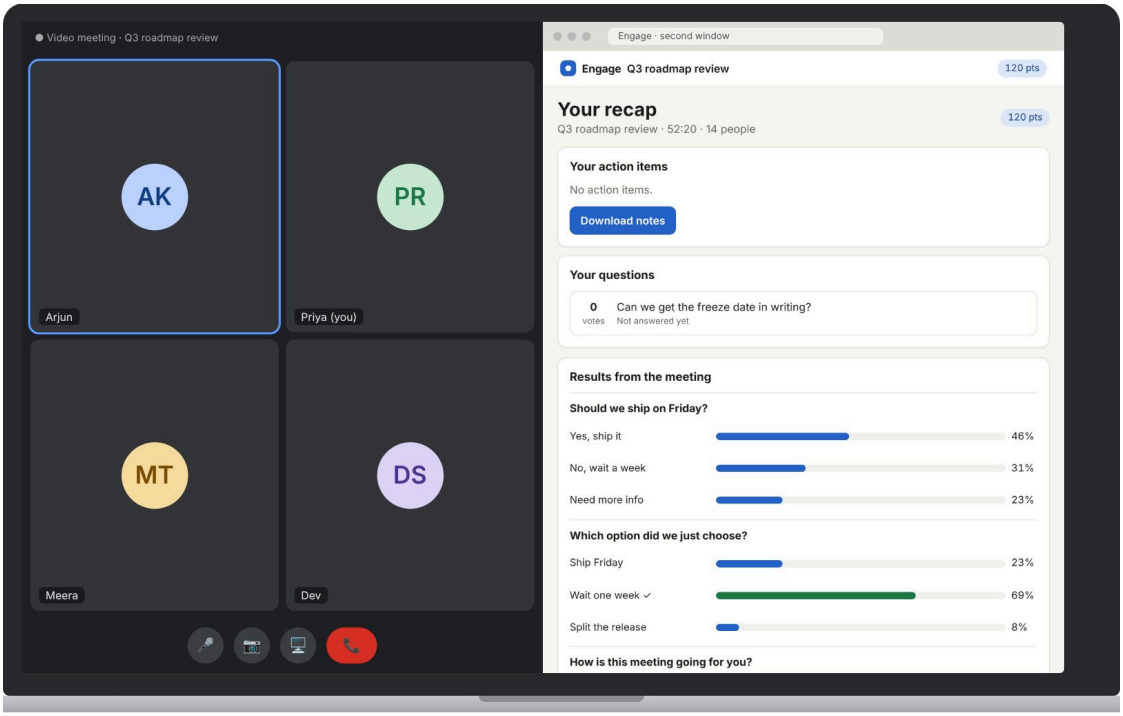




9 The meeting ends with a summary and a personal recap

The host gets duration, participation, average engagement, how evenly people took part, the results of every prompt, top questions and reactions, and can copy or download it. Each attendee gets their own recap with action items and their questions.





3. WHO SEES WHAT

Privacy rules built into the product

Information	Host	Other attendees
How many joined and took part	Yes, as counts	No
Poll, pulse and word-cloud answers	Group results only	Group results after close
Reactions	Group counts, last 2 minutes	No
Questions	Text and votes, with name unless anonymous	Text and votes, with name unless anonymous
Who is idle, quiet or on another window	Never measured	Never measured
Points, bingo card, predictions	No (prediction totals only)	No
Notes and action items	No, kept on the attendee's device	No

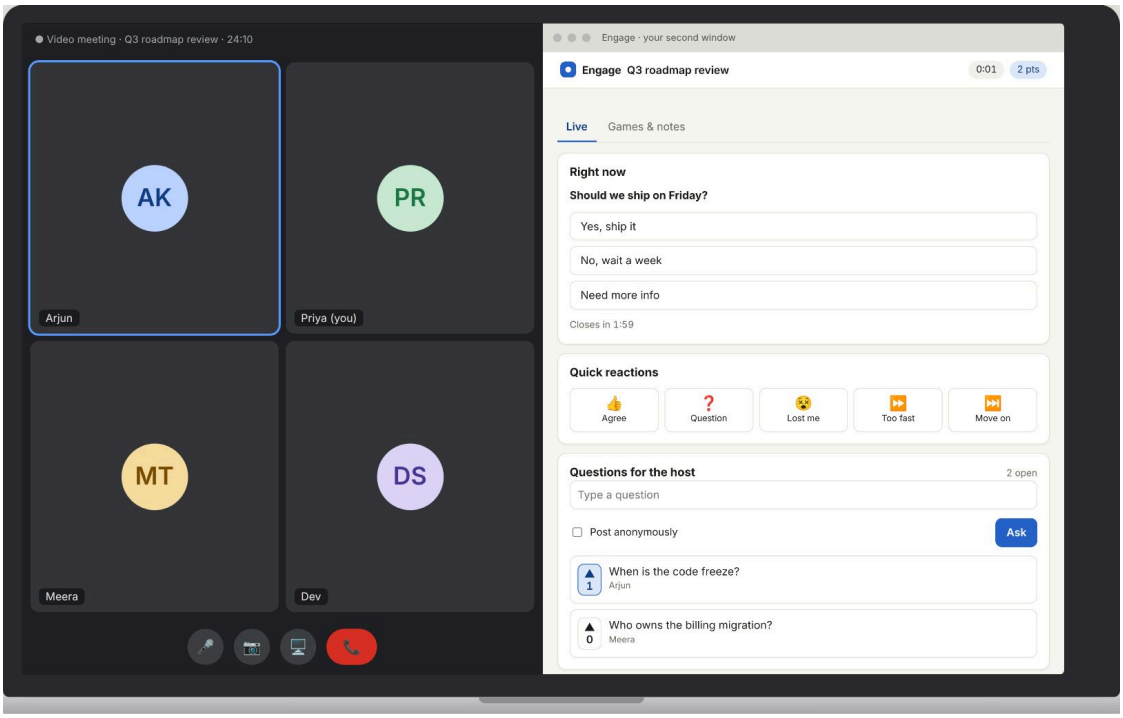
Known gap. Meetings are held in server memory today and dropped 24 hours after they end. The plan calls for 30-day retention with deletion on request, which needs a database.

4. WHERE ENGAGE LIVES ON THE LAPTOP

Three layouts, from simplest to best

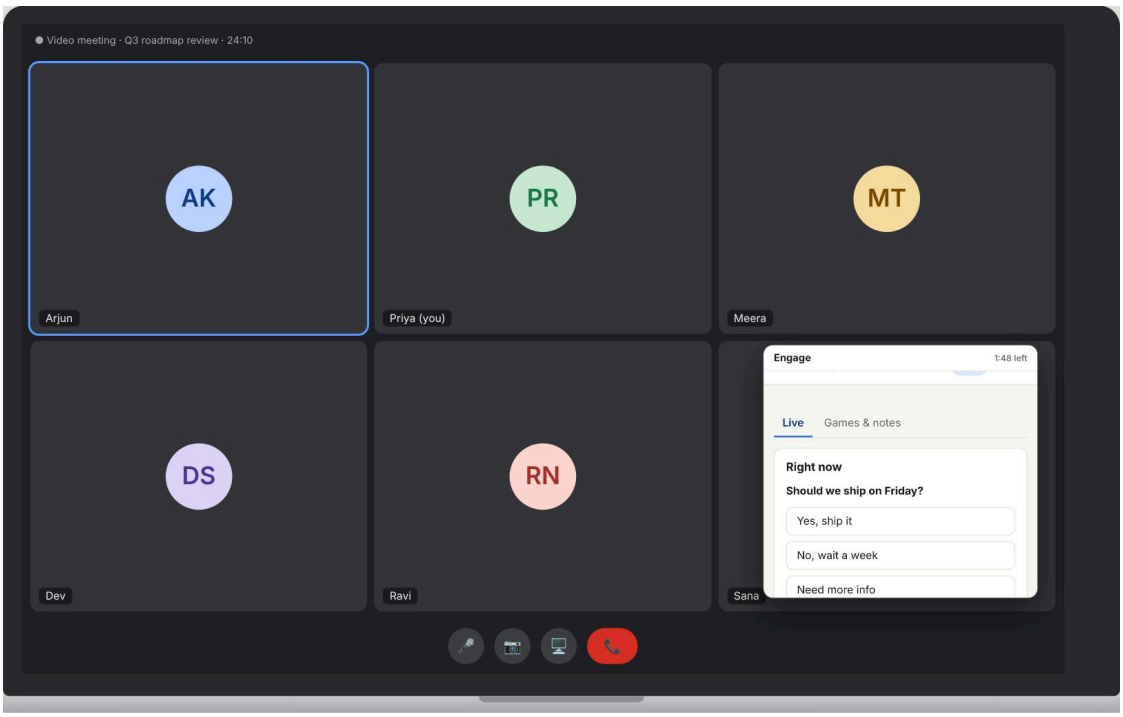
The second window can cost attention. These are the options for making it cheaper.

A. Second window beside the meeting Built



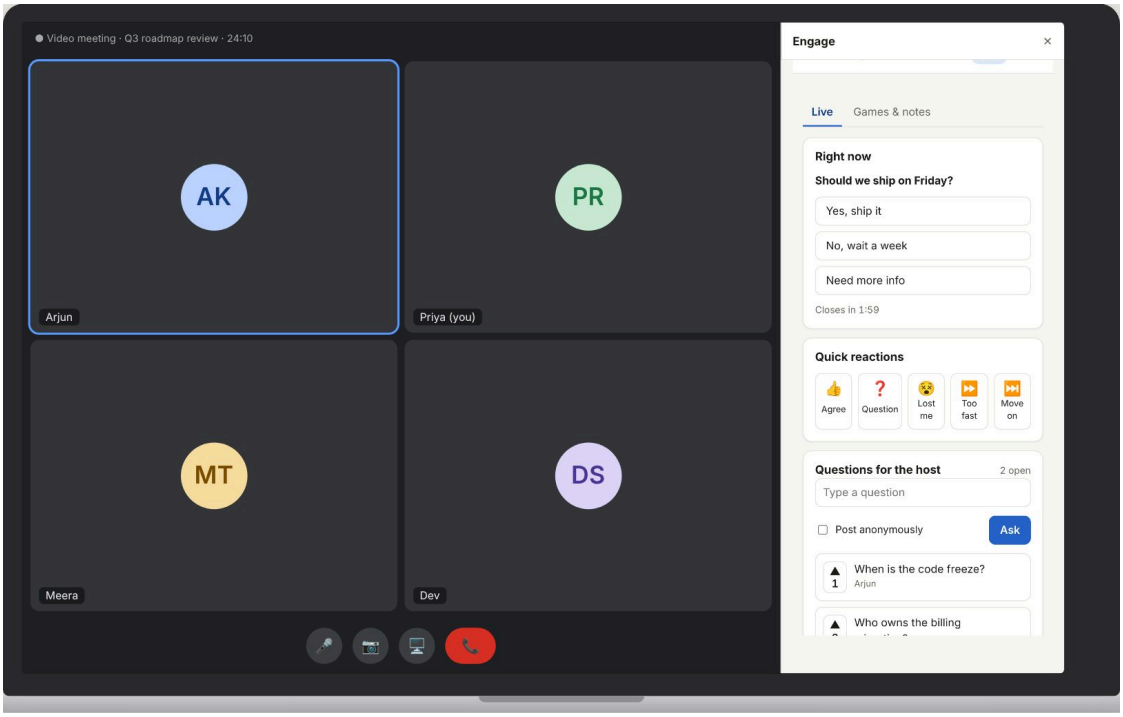
Pros: works with every meeting tool, no install. **Cons:** needs screen space and the attendee must look away from the call.

B. Floating mini window Next



Pros: no window switching, and a glance is enough. **Cons:** Chrome and Edge only, and it can appear on a shared full screen. Safari and Firefox fall back to layout A.

C. Side panel inside the meeting app Phase 2 concept



Pros: best experience, and the platform can tell Engage who is speaking and who is presenting.
Cons: built and approved separately for each meeting tool.

> **Recommendation.** Keep A for the pilots, add B next, and build C for the one meeting tool the first pilot company uses.

5. LOW-PULL DESIGN

Keeping Engage from pulling people away

"Pull" means the system drawing attention on its own. The host choosing to launch a prompt is fine. Engage popping something up unprompted is not.

Already true today

- No sound, no browser notifications, no pop-ups over other windows.
- Prompts close on their own after a time the host sets, and never repeat.
- Quiet mode (automatic pulse checks) is off by default and is the host's choice.
- One click pauses every prompt and game (Focus moment).

Planned

- A new prompt shows as a quiet badge, and the attendee opens it when they choose.
- A minimum gap between prompts, which the host can override.
- The floating mini window below, with a presenting mode.

The floating mini window has three states Planned, not built

State	What it looks like	When
Pill (default)	A small badge in a corner (about 150 by 40) with a dot when something is waiting	Always on join. Prompts do not expand it on their own
Card	The prompt, reactions and questions	Only when the attendee clicks the pill
Presenting	The window is closed. Nothing shows or queues	One click on "I'm presenting". It stays hidden until turned off

> **Limits to be honest about.** A web page cannot tell whether someone is sharing their screen. If someone shares their *entire* screen, the audience would see a floating window, so they should share a single window or tab. Only an in-meeting app (layout C) can detect the presenter. Until then, the attendee's own presenting button and the host's Focus moment are the safeguards.

How distraction is measured

Engage does not watch whether someone looked away. Distraction is measured by asking attendees after a pilot meeting: "Did Engage pull you out of the meeting?"

6. GAMES AND ATTENTION CHECKS

Minimal, and useful to the host

The aim is to keep people engaged without pulling them away, and to check that the message landed.

Option	What it is	Distraction	Verdict
Recall check	One question about the last few minutes, a 20-second timer, and a "Missed that" option. The host sees the group result only	Medium	Core, to build
Prediction	One tap, such as "Will this run over?", resolved later	Very low	Core, built
Topic bingo	Squares from agenda terms, self-marked	Low	Optional
Closing takeaway	One minute at the end to pick or write the main takeaway	Low	Optional
Buzzword bingo	Jargon squares like "synergy"	Low	Built keep as a casual template only
Team trivia	Quick rounds between teams	High	Break blocks only
Leaderboards	Public rankings	Medium	No

> **Why the recall check works.** The "Missed that" button makes it safe to be honest. The host learns how many followed (for example 70% correct, 20% missed) and can repeat or clarify. Nobody is graded. It is capped at one per 15 minutes and is the only prompt allowed to expand the mini window by itself, and never for someone in presenting mode.

Buzzword bingo is built today. The plan recommends not making it the default because jargon jokes can read as mocking the speaker or leadership.

7. LESSONS FROM READ AI

What to borrow and what to avoid

Read AI sends a bot into meetings on Zoom, Google Meet and Teams, then produces a report. Per third-party reviews, it infers engagement and sentiment from facial expressions, body language, talk time and voice, and folds them into a single score. It also offers private speaker coaching and, in some tools, a live in-meeting app. My sources are Read's own pages and reviews, with no independent check of accuracy.

	Read AI	Engage
Method	Watches and listens, then scores people	Invites people to take small actions
Consent	A bot joins the call	Attendees choose to take part
Output	Analytics after the meeting	An effect during the meeting

To borrow

Idea	Engage version	Needs
Calendar-driven setup	Create the meeting from a calendar event and add the link to the invite. No host setup	Calendar integration
Highlights at key moments	Tie the engagement chart to agenda items, such as "dipped during Budget"	Agenda segments
Private coaching	A host-only coach summary after each meeting	Nothing new
Benchmarks	Compare to your own last five meetings, never to other people	Saved history
Follow-up	Send action items and unanswered questions to email or Slack	Integrations
Live in-meeting gauge	Confirms the in-meeting app (layout C) as the long-term home	Platform apps

To avoid

- Face and voice analysis. It creates the feeling of being watched, and one review notes the EU and UK score is computed without video.
- Per-person scores shown to others, which turn engagement into a ranking.
- One opaque score with good and poor bands. Engage shows how each number is computed.
- A bot that records and transcribes by default.

Sources: Laxis review, Read AI: AI meeting coach, Unite.AI review, Read AI: Webex app, Read AI: Meeting reports.

8. ROADMAP

Phases and Phase 1 status

0. Validate
2 to 3 weeks
Prototype, host interviews, manual test meetings

1. Companion app
about 10 to 12 weeks
Core is built. Pilot meetings next

1.5 Pilot and harden
4 to 6 weeks
Persistence, privacy review, load test

2. Integrations
Meet, Zoom, Teams apps. Speaker data

3. Organization
SSO, admin, history, trends

Timelines assume a team of about three and are estimates. The prototype was built ahead of Phase 0, so the first real test is the pilot.

Phase 1 status

Milestone	Scope	Status
M1 Core loop	Link and join, reactions, questions, host room pulse	Built
M2 Moments and control	Polls, pulse checks, quizzes, word clouds, Focus moment, dip suggestions, summaries	Built
M3 Games and personal value	Bingo, predictions, game windows, private points, notes	Built
M4 Polish and quiet mode	Quiet mode built. Templates, mini window, recall check not yet	Partly built
Pilot hardening	Persistence, host access from any browser, retention, accessibility pass, load test to 200	Next

Not built yet

Floating mini window and presenting mode, recall check with "Missed that", agenda segments, host coach summary, calendar-created meetings, persistence, SSO and admin controls, speaker detection.

9. METRICS, PILOTS AND RISKS

How we will know it works

Metric	Definition	Starting target
Join rate	Joined divided by invited	Above 60%
Participation rate	Share of joined people with at least one action	Above 70%
Participation spread	Share of actions from the top 20% of people	Falling over a meeting
Repeat intent	"I would use this again"	Above 70% of attendees, all hosts
Distraction	"Engage pulled me out of the meeting"	Below 10% yes
Host effort	Host taps per meeting after setup	Under 10
Reliability	Meetings with no host-visible failure	95% or better

These targets are starting guesses. Set real ones after the first pilot meeting.

Pilot plan

- Run three real meetings with colleagues, then ask attendees and hosts the survey questions above.
- Decision rule: if participation is high and distraction is low, Phase 1 works. If participation is low, fix the interactions before adding features.

Main risks

Risk	Impact	Mitigation
Attendees see Engage as monitoring and ignore it	High	Disclosure at join, group results only, anonymous option, no rankings
Hosts forget to launch moments	High	Quiet mode, templates, agenda-driven suggestions, calendar setup
The second screen distracts or does not fit	High	Low-pull rules, mini window with presenting mode, measure distraction in pilots
Realtime breaks in a large meeting	High	Load test to 200 before wider pilots, graceful reconnect
Enterprise security review blocks pilots	Medium	Minimal data, no recording, short retention, simple privacy summary
Games feel childish	Medium	Optional, restrained, host can disable, recall check as the core

10. DECISIONS AND NEXT STEPS

What is decided and what is open

Decided

- Product name: Engage
- Laptop-first, second window beside the meeting
- Engage measures only actions inside Engage
- Group results for the host, no rankings
- Floating mini window with a collapsed state is the next layout
- Stack for the prototype: Node, WebSocket, plain HTML and JavaScript

Open

- Final game set (recommended: recall check and prediction as core)
- Whether the recall check may expand the mini window by itself
- Whether the presenting button plus Focus is enough until layout C
- Which meeting tool the first pilot company uses
- Who the first pilot hosts are, and the real team size
- Retention period and enterprise requirements

Recommended next steps

#	Step	Why
1	Find three pilot hosts and run three real meetings	The only real test of participation and distraction
2	Build the mini window with collapsed and presenting states, and the recall check	Directly addresses the distraction risk
3	Add persistence and host access from any browser	Needed before wider pilots
4	Add agenda segments and the host coach summary	Turns the chart into advice, with no integration needed
5	Add calendar-created meetings, then build an in-meeting app for the pilot company's tool	Removes host effort and the second window

Companion documents in this repository: `docs/phase1-spec.md` and `docs/product-plan.md`.